Veterinary Technologists and Technicians

Summary

Quick Facts: Veterinary Technologists and Technicians	
2021 Median Pay	$36,850 per year $17.72 per hour
Typical Entry-Level Education	Associate's degree
Work Experience in a Related Occupation	None
On-the-job Training	None
Number of Jobs, 2021	122,800
Job Outlook, 2021-31	20% (Much faster than average)
Employment Change, 2021-31	24,100

What Veterinary Technologists and Technicians Do

Veterinary technologists and technicians do medical tests that help diagnose animals' injuries and illnesses.

Work Environment

Veterinary technologists and technicians work in private clinics, laboratories, and animal hospitals. Their jobs may be physically or emotionally demanding. Many work evenings, weekends, or holidays.

How to Become a Veterinary Technologist or Technician

Veterinary technologists and technicians must complete a postsecondary program in veterinary technology. Technologists usually need a 4-year bachelor's degree, and technicians need a 2-year associate's degree. Typically, both technologists and technicians must take a credentialing exam and become registered, licensed, or certified, depending on the requirements of the state in which they work.

Pay

The median annual wage for veterinary technologists and technicians was $36,850 in May 2021.

Job Outlook

Employment of veterinary technologists and technicians is projected to grow 20 percent from 2021 to 2031, much faster than the average for all occupations.

About 15,500 openings for veterinary technologists and technicians are projected each year, on average, over the decade. Many of those openings are expected to result from the need to replace workers who transfer to different occupations or exit the labor force, such as to retire.

State & Area Data

Explore resources for employment and wages by state and area for veterinary technologists and technicians.

Similar Occupations

Compare the job duties, education, job growth, and pay of veterinary technologists and technicians with similar occupations.

More Information, Including Links to O*NET

Learn more about veterinary technologists and technicians by visiting additional resources, including O*NET, a source on key characteristics of workers and occupations.

What They Do ->

What Veterinary Technologists and Technicians Do

Veterinary technologists and technicians, supervised by licensed veterinarians, do medical tests that help diagnose animals' injuries and illnesses.

Veterinary technologists and technicians are responsible for the careful and humane handling of laboratory animals.

Duties

Veterinary technologists and technicians typically do the following:

- Observe the behavior and condition of animals
- Provide nursing care or emergency first aid to recovering or injured animals
- Bathe animals, clip nails or claws, and brush or cut animals' hair
- Restrain animals during exams or procedures
- Administer anesthesia to animals and monitor their responses
- Take x rays and collect and perform laboratory tests, such as urinalyses and blood counts
- Prepare animals and instruments for surgery
- Administer medications, vaccines, and treatments prescribed by a veterinarian
- Collect and record animals' case histories

In addition to helping veterinarians during animal exams, veterinary technologists and technicians do a variety of clinical, care, and laboratory tasks.

Veterinary technologists and technicians who work in research-related jobs ensure that animals are handled carefully and are treated humanely. They may help veterinarians or scientists on research projects in areas such as biomedical research, disaster preparedness, and food safety.

Typically working with small-animal practitioners who care for cats and dogs, veterinary technologists and technicians also may have tasks that involve mice, cattle, or other animals.

Veterinary technologists and technicians may specialize in a particular discipline, such as dentistry, anesthesia, emergency and critical care, and zoological medicine.

Veterinary technologists typically work in more advanced research-related jobs, usually under the guidance of a scientist or veterinarian. Some technologists work in private clinical practices. Working primarily in a laboratory setting, they may administer medications; prepare tissue samples for examination; or record an animal's genealogy, weight, diet, and signs of pain.

Veterinary technicians generally work in private clinical practices under the guidance of a licensed veterinarian. Technicians may do laboratory tests, such as a urinalysis, and help veterinarians conduct a variety of other diagnostic tests. Although they do some of their work in a laboratory, technicians also talk with animal owners. For example, they explain a pet's condition or how to administer medication prescribed by a veterinarian.

<- Summary

Work Environment ->

Work Environment

Work Environment

Veterinary technologists and technicians held about 122,800 jobs in 2021. The largest employers of veterinary technologists and technicians were as follows:

Veterinary services	91%
Junior colleges, colleges, universities, and professional schools; state, local, and private	3
Social advocacy organizations	2

Veterinary technologists and technicians typically work in private clinics and animal hospitals.

Veterinary technologists and technicians typically work in private clinics and animal hospitals. They also may work in laboratories, colleges and universities, and humane societies.

Their jobs may be physically or emotionally demanding. For example, they may witness abused animals or may need to help euthanize sick, injured, or unwanted animals.

Injuries and Illnesses

Veterinary technologists and technicians risk injury on the job. They may be bitten, scratched, or kicked while working with scared or aggressive animals. Injuries may happen while the technologist or technician is holding, cleaning, or restraining an animal.

Work Schedules

Veterinary technologists and technicians may have to work evenings, weekends, or holidays.

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How to Become One ->

How to Become One

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Education

Veterinary technologists usually have a 4-year bachelor's degree in veterinary technology. Veterinary technicians usually have a 2-year associate's degree in a veterinary technology program. The American Veterinary Medical Association (AVMA) accredits veterinary technology programs. Most of these programs offer a 2-year associate's degree for veterinary technicians; others offer a 4-year bachelor's degree for veterinary technologists

People interested in becoming a veterinary technologist or technician can prepare by taking biology and other science courses in high school.

Licenses, Certifications, and Registrations

Although each state regulates veterinary technologists and technicians differently, most candidates must pass a credentialing exam. Most states require technologists and technicians to pass the Veterinary Technician National Examination (VTNE), offered by the American Association of Veterinary State Boards.

Typically, both technologists and technicians must pass a credentialing exam and must become registered, licensed, or certified, depending on the state in which they work.

Important Qualities

Communication skills. Veterinary technologists and technicians communicate with supervisors, other staff, and animal owners. A growing number of technicians counsel pet owners on animal behavior and nutrition.

Compassion. Veterinary technologists and technicians must treat animals with kindness and must be sensitive when dealing with the owners of sick pets.

Detail oriented. Veterinary technologists and technicians must pay attention to detail. They must be precise when recording information, performing diagnostic tests, and administering medication.

Manual dexterity. Veterinary technologists and technicians must handle animals, medical instruments, and laboratory equipment with care. They need a steady hand for intricate tasks such as doing dental work, giving anesthesia, and taking x rays.

Physical strength. Veterinary technologists and technicians need to be able to manage and lift animals.

<- Work Environment

Pay ->

Pay

Pay

The median annual wage for veterinary technologists and technicians was $36,850 in May 2021. The median wage is the wage at which half the workers in an occupation earned more than that amount and half earned less. The lowest 10 percent earned less than $28,370, and the highest 10 percent earned more than $48,100.

In May 2021, the median annual wages for veterinary technologists and technicians in the top industries in which they worked were as follows:

Junior colleges, colleges, universities, and professional schools; state, local, and private	$46,780
Veterinary services	36,770
Social advocacy organizations	35,480

Veterinary technologists and technicians working in research positions often earn more than those in other fields.

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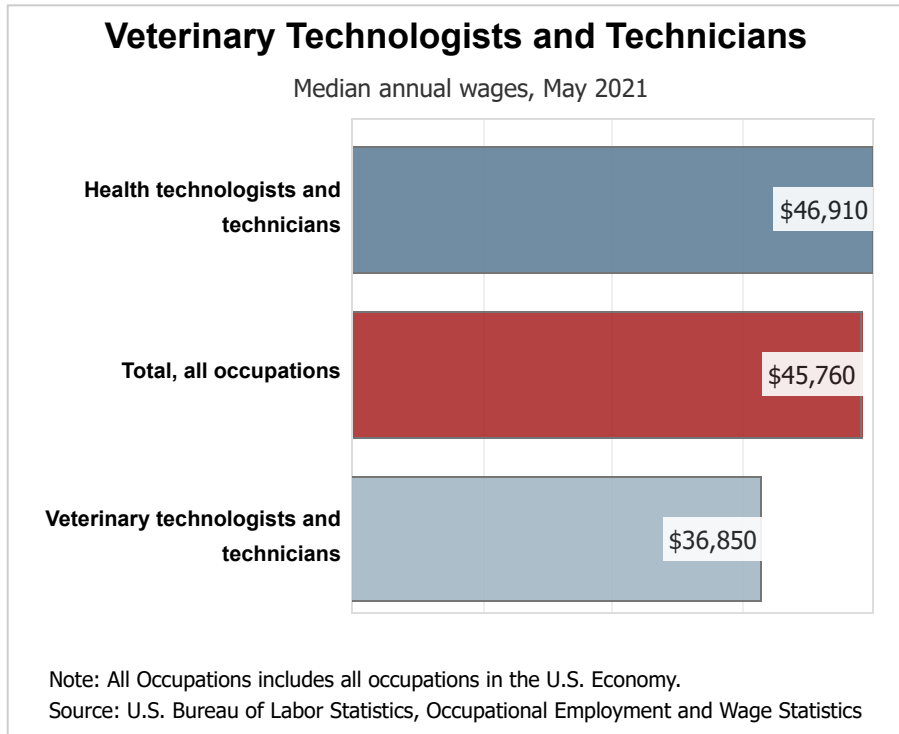

<- How to Become One

Job Outlook ->

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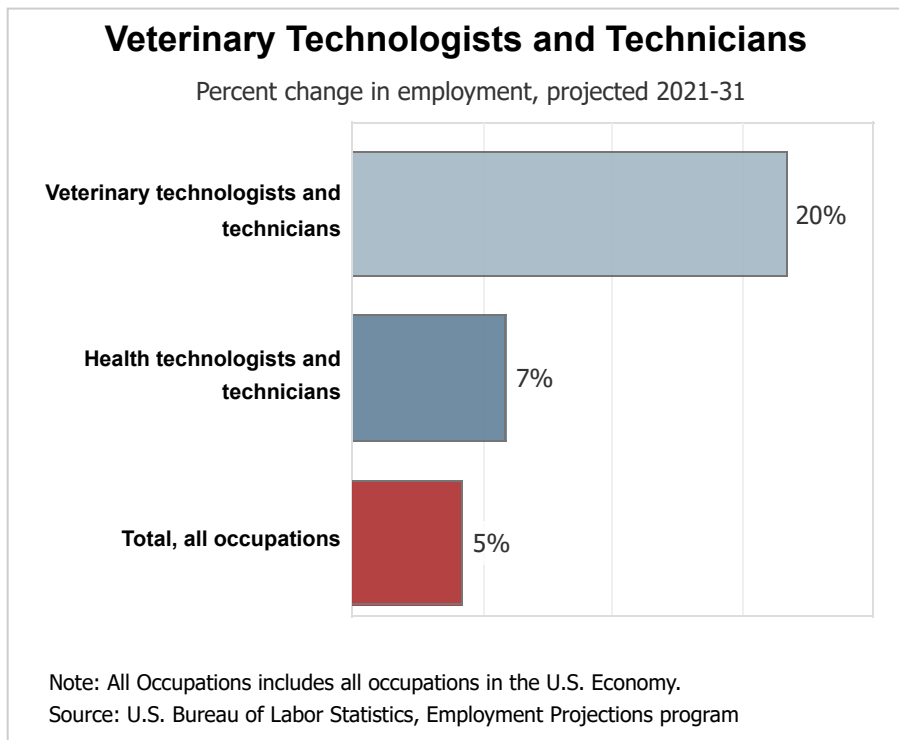
Employment

As the number of households with pets and spending on pets continue to rise, demand is expected to increase for veterinary technologists and technicians to do laboratory work and imaging services on household pets.



Employment projections data for veterinary technologists and technicians, 2021-31

Veterinary technologists and technicians
SOC Code: 29-2056
Employment, 2021: 122,800

SOURCE: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Employment Projections program

Projected Employment, 2031:
146,900

Change, 2021-31 (Percent):
20

Change, 2021-31 (Numeric):
24,100

Employment By Industry:
Get data

SOURCE: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Employment Projections program

<- Pay
State & Area Data ->
State & Area Data

State & Area Data

Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics (OEWS)

The Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics (OEWS) program produces employment and wage estimates annually for over 800 occupations. These estimates are available for the nation as a whole, for individual states, and for metropolitan and nonmetropolitan areas. The link(s) below go to OEWS data maps for employment and wages by state and area.

- Veterinary technologists and technicians

Projections Central

Occupational employment projections are developed for all states by Labor Market Information (LMI) or individual state Employment Projections offices. All state projections data are available at www.projectionscentral.org. Information on this site allows projected employment growth for an occupation to be compared among states or to be compared within one state. In addition, states may produce projections for areas; there are links to each state's websites where these data may be retrieved.

CareerOneStop

CareerOneStop includes hundreds of occupational profiles with data available by state and metro area. There are links in the left-hand side menu to compare occupational employment by state and occupational wages by local area or metro area. There is also a salary info tool to search for wages by zip code.

<- Job Outlook
Similar Occupations ->
Similar Occupations

Similar Occupations

This table shows a list of occupations with job duties that are similar to those of veterinary technologists and technicians.

Animal Care and Service Workers

Job Duties:
Animal care and service workers attend to or train animals.

Entry-Level Education:
High school diploma or equivalent

2021 Median Pay:
$28,730

Clinical Laboratory Technologists and Technicians

Job Duties:
Clinical laboratory technologists and technicians perform medical laboratory tests for the diagnosis, treatment, and prevention of disease.

Entry-Level Education:
Bachelor's degree

2021 Median Pay:
$57,800

Phlebotomists

Job Duties:
Phlebotomists draw blood for tests, transfusions, research, or blood donations.

Entry-Level Education:
Postsecondary nondegree award

2021 Median Pay:
$37,380

Radiologic and MRI Technologists

Job Duties:
Radiologic technologists perform diagnostic imaging examinations on patients. MRI technologists operate magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) scanners to create diagnostic images.

Entry-Level Education:
Associate's degree

2021 Median Pay:
$61,980

Surgical Assistants and Technologists

Job Duties:

Surgical assistants and technologists help with surgical operations.

Entry-Level Education:
Postsecondary nondegree award

2021 Median Pay:
$48,510

Veterinarians

Job Duties:
Veterinarians care for the health of animals and work to protect public health.

Entry-Level Education:
Doctoral or professional degree

2021 Median Pay:
$100,370

Veterinary Assistants and Laboratory Animal Caretakers

Job Duties:
Veterinary assistants and laboratory animal caretakers handle routine animal care and help scientists, veterinarians, and others with their daily tasks.

Entry-Level Education:
High school diploma or equivalent

2021 Median Pay:
$29,780

<- State & Area Data

More Info ->

More Info

Contacts for More Information

For information about careers in veterinary medicine and a listing of AVMA-accredited veterinary technology programs, visit

American Veterinary Medical Association

For more information about becoming a veterinary technician or technologist, visit

National Association of Veterinary Technicians in America

For information about certification as a laboratory animal technician or technologist, visit

American Association for Laboratory Animal Science

For information about the Veterinary Technician National Examination (VTNE), visit

American Association of Veterinary State Boards

Related BLS articles

Beyond the Numbers: "Ahead of the pack: why are veterinary occupations growing much faster than average?"

O*NET

Veterinary Technologists and Technicians

<- Similar Occupations

SUGGESTED CITATION:

Bureau of Labor Statistics, U.S. Department of Labor, *Occupational Outlook Handbook*, Veterinary Technologists and Technicians, at https://www.bls.gov/ooh/healthcare/veterinary-technologists-and-technicians.htm (visited *March 16, 2023*).

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